

AREA 6.6: INTERIOR DOOR AND GRAVITY SWITCH

The exterior door here opens to reveal an interior door 40 feet beyond. Past the interior door, a side passage lined with ladders leads off to area 5.2, while the main shaft continues down into darkness, eventually reaching area 6.42 nearly 600 feet below.

If characters coming down from area 6.6 try to walk into area 5.2, they find it unexpectedly difficult as gravity shifts, making area 5.2 appear to be above them. However, the effect is only disorienting—not potentially deadly as it is for characters coming from area 5.2 (see that area's description for details).

AREA 6.7: WATERLOGGED BOAT

An ordinary wooden rowboat, similar to any the characters would have seen in the port they started out from, lies here among the cubic landscape, filled nearly to the brim with the murky black water of the Styx sea. The rowboat belonged to a large merchant vessel that recently landed on the island. The hydrolaths sunk the ship and killed the crew, but the sunken rowboat was caught in the gravitational pull of face 6. Because it remains full of Styx water, the boat hasn't pixelated yet.

AREA 6.8: GUARDROOM

The features of this area appear different depending on whether the characters have an unpixelated view.

Pixelated. Four iron ladders lead down into a square chamber, lit by panels in the blocky walls that glow with a soft white light. Gray tables, chairs, and benches are made of rectangles and blocks. Vaguely weapon-like items also made of blocks hang on rungs set into the walls. Six faceless, blocky humanoid figures stand against the walls.

Unpixelated. In addition to normal tables, chairs, and benches, this room features walls lined with rivets and pipes, round glass panels that glow with light, and a number of weapons on weapons racks. A water jug, six mugs, some hunks of unidentifiable meat, rulers, calipers, crossbows, bolts, and valueless personal items are scattered about.

Pixelated Guards. The six figures here are three pixelated **merregons**^M and three pixelated **veterans**—fanatical defenders of the cube who see all nonpixelated beings as grotesque mutants. If the characters don't seem immediately threatening, the pixelated guards offer to escort them to the reception room (area 6.13). They won't let anyone roam the cube without escorts. If the characters broke through the interior door or otherwise displayed violent tendencies, five of the guards attack while the sixth goes to alert the skull lord at area 6.31.

AREA 6.9: GUARDROOM

This area is identical to area 6.8, and contains three pixelated **merregons**^M and three pixelated **veterans**.

AREA 6.10: GUARDROOM

This area is identical to area 6.8, and contains three pixelated **merregons**^M and three pixelated **veterans**.

AREA 6.11: UPPER LEVEL BARRACKS

The features of this area appear different depending on whether the characters have an unpixelated view.

Pixelated. This high-ceilinged room resembles a warehouse or a prison cell block, with ladders leading up to several levels of walkways. Along each level are numerous black metal doors fitted with small, square-barred windows. Most windows reveal identical cell-like rooms beyond, each containing only shelves in the walls and a number of large blocks or cubes. One cell along each section of wall is instead empty, and tiled in white. The cell doors have no locks. Blocky machines stand in the central corridor between the rows of cells, and the whole area is lit by white glowing bricks in the walls.

Unpixelated. The individual rooms contain bunk beds, tables, crates, simple toilets, sinks, and other plain furniture. A few hold personal items such as dishes, weapons, and cloth rags.

Warriors' Quarters. These rooms were previously inhabited by the Acheronian army that inhabited the cube. The many empty rooms contain only valueless personal items. Characters who thoroughly explore the barracks also find occasional cells that contain incomprehensible machinery or pipes leaking magical fluids.

Slime Showers. Each of the white-tiled chambers features a large pixelated drain at the center of its floor, and a large pixelated faucet on the wall. If the faucet is turned, a bubbling sound emerges from the drain, followed by an eruption of white pixelated slime that moves across the floor as if alive. The white slime is a hazard that eats only dead organic material, and is used by the soldiers to clean themselves. If any characters allow the slime to crawl up their bodies, it presses against them to cleanse them of sweat, dead skin, and dirt—along with any nonmagical clothing and gear with an organic origin (including most cloth, leather, and wood). The slime flows back into the drain when its cleaning is done, or if attacked.

Food and Water Dispensers. The blocky machines are fountain-like devices operated by buttons, tubes, and cranks. One dispenses small waxed-paper boxes holding water, which can be pierced open and drunk. The other machine dispenses soft cubes of macerated meat-like pulp made from the flesh of lemures—creatures unworthy of being soldiers and condemned to be eaten by their betters. Unpixelated food takes the form of a sloppy paste instead of a cube. It is harmless to eat, though extremely unappetizing.

Off-Duty Threats. The pixelated guards come here in shifts to eat, drink, and rest. When the characters first arrive, nine pixelated **merregons**^M and nine pixelated **veterans** are resting in rooms or wandering the central corridors. The maximum number of guards here will easily overwhelm even a 13th-level party, so a stealthy approach is warranted—and characters might need to flee if a serious fight breaks out. Additionally, unless the characters are stealthy, creatures in areas 6.11A, 6.11B, or 6.11C hear them when they enter 6.11.

Every 4 hours, six of the guards here switch out with guards in areas 6.8, 6.9, 6.10, 6.19, or 6.20.

AREA 6.11A. OINOLOTH'S ROOM

Malika Tahoun ("Queen Plague") dwells in this area. The **oinoloth**^M appears as an unpixelated humanoid figure that is completely covered so that none of its flesh is visible. It wears leather robes, a stained apron, leather boots and gloves, and a bird-faced leather mask and helmet with a long beak and two smoked-glass goggles over the eyes. Two pixelated **merregons**^M with halberds stand within 5 feet of it at all times, watching it and preventing it from leaving the cube.

This cell is distinguished from the others by two pixelated bodies on the table inside (playthings of the oinoloth) and a partially pixelated ivory chess set worth 100 gp (a gift from the skull lord). Any character with a passive Wisdom (Perception) score of 18 or higher smells the blood from the room just passing by through area 6.11. The oinoloth has no treasure. Any mortal foolish enough to wear its leather robes or mask is infected by horrible diseases of your devising.

Fiendish Bargains. Malika surrendered to the skull lord when the rest of the yugoloth away team were killed. The magic suit it wears protects it from the pixelating curse. Respecting it as a potential ally—and unable to claim its plague-ridden head—the skull lord is waiting to see if it becomes necessary to have the oinoloth become part of the Six-Face Throne. The oinoloth is happy to wait—and is hopeful that other yugoloths or Bane's forces mount a more successful assault on the cube.

Using its telepathy, the oinoloth can communicate with the characters without being overheard by its guards. In the interest of gaining their aid, it uses its Corrupted Healing to heal wounded characters or cure the pixelating curse. This triggers a fight with the attending merregons at once.

The oinoloth knows almost everything the skull lord knows, and can also tell the characters about the *censer of blood* that it lost somewhere on face 5. But if the characters agree to aid it, the selfish and evil oinoloth doesn't risk its hide in a face-to-face fight with the skull lord or its servants. It instead leaves the cube as soon as possible, taking the censer with it if it can—preferably by killing one or more characters for it.

AREA 6.11B. SLADEK'S ROOM

If he has not been encountered already, Sladek the wizard is 50 percent likely to be in this room when the characters enter area 6.11. Otherwise, he is in area 6.23.

Sladek is completely pixelated, but he can be easily identified from among the other pixel guards by his blue coloring (from his genasi skin and blue robes) and his tall, conically cubic wizard's hat. Any character who succeeds on a DC 10 Intelligence (Insight) check makes the connection that this is the mage they're looking for.

Sladek now willingly serves the skull lord as a trusted advisor, and he happily betrays the party to Vargo even if the characters are former friends or allies. Sladek is a pixelated **mage**, giving him the following changes:

- His alignment is lawful neutral.
- He has telepathy out to a range of 120 feet, but can use it to communicate only with other pixelated creatures.

Being attuned to the Six-Face Throne, he can also communicate telepathically with the skull lord at any distance.

- He is immune to the frightened condition.
- He has advantage on Dexterity (Stealth) checks made to hide while in a pixelated area.

If Sladek casts any spells that produce a visual effect, that effect is pixelated.

Wizard's Work. A pixelated *driftglobe* lights the room, which is filled with pixelated wizards' equipment. Sladek's spellbook (identifiable as a large violet book but illegible unless unpixelated) sits on his chair. Tables in the room have been set up with alchemical equipment, with which Sladek studies the interactions of different types of pixelated matter. The equipment is visible as pixelated glass tubes in which pixelated liquids stir and pixelated green, red, and blue flames flicker. The equipment can be used or sold as alchemist's supplies.

In one corner of the room, a small chest is inscribed with a *glyph of warding* that is impossible to see when the chest is pixelated. When unpixelated, it can be found with a successful DC 14 Intelligence (Investigation) check. Opening the chest triggers the glyph's *cloudkill* spell. Within the chest are a *potion of healing*, two *potions of climbing*, and a *spell scroll of control water*.

AREA 6.11C: SIMAK'S ROOM

The drow captain Simak is found lurking in her cell when the characters pass through this area. She is here whenever she is not playing court jester to Vargo. After seeing her forces annihilated by the skull lord and its servants, she escaped the same fate only by pretending to have been rendered an entertaining idiot by the effects of the Styx sea. Amused, Vargo lets her wander the cube freely, but the pixelated guards have orders to not let her reach the surface.

Simak knows the skull lord's plans and the oinoloth's powers. She looks constantly for any opportunity to escape the cube, and might reveal her subterfuge to the characters if she thinks they might help her. Naturally, she betrays them immediately if doing so helps her escape.

Simak is a **drow house captain** (see *Mordenkainen's Tome of Foes*) with the following changes:

- Her Intelligence is 14 and she has Deception +5.
- She has a +1 bonus to attack rolls and damage rolls with her magic weapons (see below).
- She also carries a mundane poisoned dagger hidden in her boot: +8 to hit; 6 (1d4 + 4) piercing damage plus 14 (4d6) poison damage.

Simak has become aware that her *amulet of the Styx* is the reason she has not pixelated like other creatures. (See the "New Magic Items" appendix for details on the amulet.) She also wears a white spider-silk cape (300 gp), a chrysoberyl ring (150 gp), and an alexandrite ring (600 gp), and she carries a pouch holding *oil of slipperiness*, three doses of assassin's blood poison, and five doses of drow poison. See chapter 8 of the *Dungeon Master's Guide* for information on poisons.

Simak's *+1 hand crossbow*, *+1 scimitar*, and *+1 whip*, all clearly of drow make, are hidden under some pixelated rags beneath the lower bunk.

AREA 6.11D: LADDER SHAFT

A 20-foot-wide shaft with ladders on all four sides runs some 200 feet between the upper and middle levels beneath face 6. When Cube 1717 was fully functional, magic in the shaft allowed freight and important individuals to levitate up and down, but that magic has failed.

AREA 6.12: TEMPLE OF THE CUBE

The features of this area appear different depending on whether the characters have an unpixelated view.

Pixelated. This blocky chamber has an arched cathedral-like roof, lit by partially hidden glowing white wall panels high in the nave. Long black rectangular benches face a huge gray block with the crude outline of a noseless face engraved on all its visible sides. Lying on its side in the back of the chamber is a smaller blocky statue of black metal, apparently depicting an armored humanoid.

Unpixelated. The room is a temple, with an elaborate cathedral roof and black pews facing the central object of worship. This place was once a temple to Bane, the god of tyranny, whom the fallen statue depicts as a tall man in dark knightly armor. The statue has been desecrated and replaced with a recently forged statue of the Archquadrone. However, hymns to Bane in Infernal are still scribed on the walls.

A successful DC 20 Intelligence (Arcana) check identifies the new steel statue as resembling the body of a quadrone without its arms, legs, and wings. Its face has a lordly expression, as if about to speak a command.

Once per day on a regular schedule, all the pixelated guards come here to pray. Each time the characters enter this area, roll a d6. On a 1, three pixelated **merregons**^M and three pixelated **veterans** are here, rapt in worship and easy to surprise.

AREA 6.13: RECEPTION ROOM

The features of this area appear different depending on whether the characters have an unpixelated view.

Pixelated. This room is lit by glowing white squares in the ceiling and floor. Several angular chairs and divans face a crude, blocky metal desk on a square dais, behind which sits a high-backed blocky chair. A red-skinned, naked humanoid sits in the high-backed chair, possessed of a grotesque, hairless head and long bat wings.

Behind the desk are numerous cabinets and chests of drawers, and a strange, blocky machine. Crudely angular gray statues stand about the room, with a vague resemblance to humanoids in armor.

Unpixelated. This place has the appearance of a mundane waiting room—except for the features appropriate to the Lower Planes. The statues depict Bane, Loviatar, and other mighty lawful evil beings. The cabinets and chests are filled with writing instruments, paperwork, and scrolls in Infernal listing the names of countless dead souls who ended up in Acheron due to their service (conscious

or otherwise) of Bane, Loviatar, and Tiamat—the lords of tyranny, cruelty, and greed. The machine is a water dispenser (see area 6.11). Despite their angular appearance, the chairs and divans are quite comfortable.

Welcoming Committee. The bat-winged humanoid is Bunch, a **berbalang**^M ally of the skull lord. Bunch is resistant to the pixelating curse because of the creature's extraplanar nature. Though it has the appearance of a devil, the berbalang is not a fiend at all. Rather, it came to the cube for the vast wealth of bodies upon it, which it plunders for the chance to speak with the dead. It gladly agreed to assist the skull lord and its pixelated servants in exchange for access to these riches, which it gathers in area 6.45.

When the characters arrive here, the berbalang is working where the bureaucrats of the cube once sorted new arrivals to Acheron, welcoming them to an afterlife of eternal servitude and war. It welcomes the adventurers as if mistaking them for dead souls, asking them what they did when they were alive, what they would like to do in their new existence in the afterlife, and so on.

The berbalang's seemingly misguided questions have an evil design. It was been charged by Vargo with noting and delivering any intelligent visitors that have come to the cube, so that the skull lord can steal their skulls to activate more faces of the Six-Face Throne (see area 6.28). The berbalang takes special note of wizard characters, and might also ask other characters to take

